

Christian Hip-Hop and Moral Privilege*

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Narrative thinking is substantial in our lives as it provides ways of thinking about how our lives may have gone differently, and how our lives may go differently. I defend Christian Hip-Hop as a moral technology that has ethical implications in a cultural context. As a moral technology, I argue that it defines alternative plans for the future, most notably, the plans we have regarding ourselves, i.e., our identity, and our relationships to others. These considerations provide a novel way of thinking about how our lives may go differently.

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Introduction

In his paper *Narrative Thinking, Emotion, and Planning*, Peter Goldie argues that narrative is substantial in our lives as it provides ways of thinking about how our lives may have gone differently, our plans for the future, and how things might turn out (non-actual episodes). This is a very important concept. Namely, the prospect of being able to imagine, for instance, what a good life will look like for you. Imagining what your spouse will look like, where you will buy your first home, how many children you will have. You might ask yourself what you will see when you look out the window in the morning, will you see ocean, mountains, desert, or forest? Some imagine rearing their children on the same street that they learned to ride a bike on, and imagine taking their family three doors down to their parents' for Sunday dinner.

This concept of narrative thinking and planning is also important for goal formation. We can develop a sense of agency when what we imagine, plays a role in the way things turn out for us. The image of ourselves performing a life-saving surgery on a patient may give us the extra motivation we need to stay awake long hours in preparation for becoming a surgeon.

More importantly, we can develop a sense of agency when we imagine ways in which our friendships, family ties, and other important relationships will go. We can imagine the type of person we are to others and take needed steps for becoming that person. As such, the person we will be is the goal that is formed by a narrative. Consider one particular narrative, we imagine ourselves as thoughtful, kind, considerate, loving, or compassionate. Imagining ourselves this way becomes the motivation we need to read up on the latest methods of counseling. We might imagine ourselves being invited to witness the birth of a friend's first child and scour the internet for advice on how to find the perfect gift. We might imagine ourselves handing a hot cup of tea to a friend who is facing an impending divorce and read the latest books on divorce and counseling another through them.

While the argument that the way we imagine our lives going can have a positive causal effect on the kind of person we become, one may argue that this view is too optimistic. A question can be raised here. To what extent do the experiences we have, shape the person we become? For instance, Eric J. (mill20?) argues that victimhood imposes normative standards that ground the moral status of the victim. What he means is that social roles, such as victim, determine the values we are expected to live by. As a victim, there are various normative standards imposed on us that undermine our ability to uphold our other moral duties, such as protecting and nurturing our children. One reason

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is that when victims as parents, or the parents of victims, instructs a child, they must instruct them to act in self-subordinating ways “when confronted by the police” [221]. While there is much that can be stressed on this point, what is important, is that a theory of narrative identity may attempt to absolve the tension by defining the agency of the would-be victim in some other way that does not involve victimhood. For instance, we may think that self-subordination is largely defined by a narrative arc, what is sub-ordination in one context, is taking ownership of one’s actions in another, taking responsibility over what one does, or did. This narrative arc gives meaning to a sequence the events the narrative is comprised of. What the events mean then, is largely determined by that narrative (**sche96?**).

Narrative Thinking, Planning, and Agency

When we make plans for the future, we are often constrained in various ways. These ways may include facts about ourselves, we may not be tall enough to go on a given amusement park ride. Or have the necessary professional qualifications for a given job on the coast. Sometimes we are constrained by contingent facts about ourselves. These can include our personalities, our character traits, our emotional health and dispositions, or our abilities. Other times these constraints are external, such as past events. We can be permanently injured from a previous automobile accident. Inflation and the economy can prevent us from taking a vacation this year. We can be constrained by other people, as when someone rear-ends us and instead of driving to Yosemite, we have to get our car fixed. We can be constrained by the plans that others may have for themselves, and by extension, us; say in the case of marriage. Sometimes we are constrained by another’s personal policies, for instance, because we do not profess religious faith, our friend’s felt obligations to their religious parents may prevent them from accepting our marriage proposal.

Past experiences are connected to counterfactual thinking and regrets. The ways we reflect on these experiences and how we are constrained by them can sometimes lead to counterfactual thinking and regrets. We can regret the fact that our friend’s parents do not think of us as a legitimate suitor.

There are times wherein these constraints, experiences and the regrets they lead to are real, occurring and constraining our choices in real-life. Goldie, however, argues that there are also times that while the constraints and regrets take place in real-life, the experience is make-believe or some other fictional event, what he calls non-local events. Non-local events are ones that take place in the past, future or make-believe, but both can be a part of a fiction. Both the real-life experiences, and the fictional ones are conveyed through narratives. A narrative is a representation of a sequence of events, whether actual, or make-believe. We can imagine someone telling us a fictional account of a purported historical event. Imagine that a friend, as a prank, calls you and tells you that he saw a random DUI check point on the way you normally take home from work. The local law-enforcement has decided that they need to do more to combat driving under the influence and this check-point is the result of that decision. You know from experience that such check-points usually increase commute times by forty-five minutes to an hour. Assuming that you believe your friend and you take an alternative way home, which on any other given day, adds thirty-five minutes to your commute, you are constrained from getting home thirty-five minutes sooner because of a fictional event. Through his fictional narrative, your friend has represented a sequence of events to you that constrained your choices. These constraints can motivate feelings of regret, for instance if your spouse is waiting on you to make a dinner reservation.

We can represent both real-life and make-believe events through narrative and both can constrain

our choices in real-life. More specifically, a narrative is the mental representation of a sequence of events. Your friend may recount how he waited in traffic for over an hour thinking that there was a vehicle accident up ahead. These can be a sequence of thoughts, thought through, and conceived of by both the narrator and the audience. We imagine ourselves also sitting in traffic for over an hour. The narrative can represent timelines which can be conscious or subconscious and they can provide coherence of the causal and other connections between events into what is called a narrative episode or episodes. We might imagine a counterfactual timeline wherein we wait in traffic over an hour, completely missing our dinner reservation and much needed time with our spouse.

What we can glean from these episodes are coherence, meaningfulness, and emotional importance/import. In imagining the counterfactual where we sit in traffic for over an hour, we may realize that we are really looking forward to having dinner with our spouse. We might realize that we have both been working really late and have not set enough time apart for each other. Goldie says that emplotment, is a psychological process which can be more or less successful. Emplotment occurs for those implicated in the narrative and those who engage with the narrative. Through emplotment, narratives give those who are implicated by them and those who engage with them, ways to consciously or subconsciously think about the events mentally represented by that narrative.

You consider how much time would be added to your commute if you went the way home that you normally would. The story your friend has told you, comes with some emotional baggage then. Realizing that you miss your spouse, you regret that you might miss your dinner reservation etc. This emotional baggage, and not the actual conditions, in part, is what determines the appropriateness of your response, whether you will take your usual way, or the other. Assuming you decide to avoid the fake DUI check-point, your response is emotionally appropriate because it is a response to how much you miss your spouse. Assuming that missing the dinner reservation equates to what most of us think of as a negatively valenced experience, taking the longer route would be the appropriate response in this situation. As such, this decision is emotionally important.

II. Emotional Import

But when we think about this emotional import, the effect on our behavior may differ from the emotional import of a real-life but non-local event and a make-believe non-local event. This implies though, that the proper response to a situation is outlined by the emotional response to a given event whether true or make-believe. Especially because it seems that it is the narrative that outlines the proper emotional response and not real-life. Both narratives are non-local events, but one is real-life and the other make-believe. Our friend may say to us; “oh man, you don’t wanna go that way let me tell you . . .” at which point he spins a yarn about his commute taking one and a half hours longer than it does normally and it is this yarn that motivated your counterfactual experiences and subsequent feelings of regret. As such

1. Narratives first seem to outline the proper emotional response to a given event.

But, then they are also,

2. distinct from emotions that are an agent’s response to a given event or sequence of events.
(See gold08?)

The distinction then is between emotional import and emotional response. We ought to contrast these two features.

1. emotional import is an integral part of the narrative

2. emotional response is a response to it

We may have felt the fear in our friend's voice. We see the frustration on his face while he tells the story. If he is even somewhat adequate at doing so, it is us who feels the same frustration. We are transplanted into the story where as the character, we experience the apt emotions, but we can also experience emotions externally. The external emotions that we experience are not as necessary. Assuming that I am drawn into the narrative, I have one emotional experience, the one that is apt in the context. However, as an audience member, I can also have emotional experiences that are responses to my response in the story. I might read Anne Frank and I am drawn into her narrative experiencing the emotions that are apt in that context. However, as an external audience member, in response to the pain and fear that I feel internally, my external response is one of anger.

2 Second example, where they differ This can similarly occur in real-life personal narratives as well. We can imagine an office employee being humiliated at a team meeting by a senior member of the team and then recalling his humiliation later that evening, he responds emotionally with anger and rage. Here, the agent as character was humiliated by a more senior member at work and in the moment, all they could feel is humiliation, embarrassment, and shame. However, taking an external perspective on what happened, they "might conceive of what happened as deserving anger and resentment."

By thinking through these narratives, we make the emotions appropriate in response to the narrative. This can occur with dramatic irony, the narrator is not aware of crucial facts about what happened until later and as such, the external emotion, the one in response to the internal emotion is different from the internal one.

Narrative Thinking and Planning

Counterfactual imagining occurs in the same way. When we imagine who we want to be, we may begin by thinking of what steps we can actively take to become that person. If we imagine ourselves to be financially independent, we may choose a college major in a field that promises a large salary. However, sometimes, once we set out on a path to becoming the person we desire, external constraints can reveal to us the feasibility of our goals. Upon entering university, we may have thought that we wanted a career in computer science but realizing how difficult the math is, we may think it is not worth it. Other factors can also constrain our choices.

There are two kinds of factors, positive and negative ones. A negative constraint is one wherein we pursue computer science but struggle with the math and decide we would rather study philosophy. A positive constraint however, is one wherein while we may be okay doing the math required by the CS field, it would detract too much from what we really liked about CS which is the analytic structure of argument. It turns out that what we liked in computer science was the logic and not so much the math. Therefore we switch majors to philosophy instead. This is an example of a positive constraint. We discover some additional desire that we have and this constrains our choice. We realize that we want to become a physician and do humanitarian work in an organization like doctors without borders. We recognize that this will require many hours of study and does not promise a large salary. As such, it would leave us with very little time for romantic relationships and there is no financial compensation to justify the time away from loved ones. Therefore, we breakup with our college girlfriend. The positive constraint highlights an emerging goal or desire. This emerging goal or desire reveals new steps that we should take including breaking up with our girlfriend.

The steps here being referenced are hypothetical imperatives, they are imperatives about what we should do given our stated goals. While hypotheticals imperatives are implied by positive constraints, there is not initially a similar object with respect to negative constraints. For instance, we may think that negative constraints are associated not with *oughts*, but with *ought-nots*, but it is not clear.

- Hypotheticals imperatives == oughts in light of stated goals
- When you fall short of these goals, you experience negative emotions.
- the negative emotions motivate counterfactual thinking, thinking back to the crucial moment that contributed to your failure to realize your goals
- Regret is an external emotion that arises in response to your decision underlying your goal failure
- Each, negative emotions, counterfactual narrative thinking, and regrets can have a feedback effect on one's grasp of the related hypothetical imperatives, helping one to learn from one's mistakes. Negative emotions then motivate counterfactual thinking.

Works Cited